

TAXILA BUSINESS SCHOOL

Instructor's Manual: Sector Shaker- The India Challenge

1. Introduction

Welcome, facilitator! The **Sector Shaker Challenge** is a dynamic 5-year business simulation developed at Taxila Business School, Jaipur. It is designed to immerse students in the fundamentals of market strategy, competitive analysis, and financial decision-making within the context of the vibrant Indian economy.

This manual provides a comprehensive guide for instructors to effectively facilitate the simulation, guide student learning, and lead insightful debrief sessions.

2. Learning Objectives

By participating in this simulation, students will:

- **Analyze Market Environments:** Evaluate the potential, trends, and competitive landscape of various industries.
- **Develop Strategic Positioning:** Formulate Unique Selling Propositions (USPs) to create a competitive advantage.
- **Allocate Financial Resources:** Manage a marketing budget effectively across different channels to maximize return on investment.
- **Craft Marketing Communications:** Understand the importance of targeted messaging and its impact on customer conversion.
- **Adapt to Market Changes:** Make decisions in a dynamic environment where competitors innovate and the market evolves annually.
- **Practice Data-Informed Decision-Making:** Use simulated market feedback (like surveys) to refine strategy.

3. Simulation Flow & Facilitator's Role

The simulation unfolds over five phases, each offering key opportunities for instruction and discussion.

Phase 1: Choose Your Battlefield

- **Student Action:** Students select a market sector to enter.
- **Facilitator's Role:** Encourage students to justify their choice.
 - **Discussion Prompts:**
 - *"Why did you choose this sector? Were you attracted by the high growth rate, the large customer base, or something else?"*
 - *"What potential challenges do you foresee in this market? Is it highly competitive? Is the average spending power low?"*

Phase 2: Market Intelligence & Company Creation

- **Student Action:** Students analyze competitors and define their company's name and three USPs.
- **Facilitator's Role:** This is the most crucial phase for strategic thinking. Emphasize the importance of strong, differentiated USPs.
 - **Discussion Prompts:**
 - *"Look at the market leader's USPs. What are their weaknesses? How can your USPs directly challenge them?"*
 - *"Are your USPs specific and measurable, or are they generic terms like 'good quality'? Remember, the AI rewards innovation and specificity (e.g., 'AI-powered logistics' is better than 'fast delivery')."*

Phase 3: Launch Assessment

- **Student Action:** The simulation's AI provides an initial valuation and feedback.
- **Facilitator's Role:** Use the AI's remarks to anchor a discussion on strategy.
 - **Discussion Prompts:**
 - *"Based on the AI's feedback, was your initial strategy disruptive, solid, or conventional? Why?"*
 - *"How does your initial turnover compare to the established players? What does this tell you about the challenge ahead?"*

Phase 4: Annual Strategy & Execution

- **Student Action:** Students allocate their annual marketing budget, craft messages, and conduct follow-up campaigns.
- **Facilitator's Role:** Guide discussions around the marketing funnel and resource allocation.
 - **Discussion Prompts:**
 - **Budgeting:** *"What was the rationale for your budget mix? Why did you favor digital over print, or vice-versa?"*
 - **Lead Conversion:** *"You have a number of unconverted leads. Is it better to spend more money to get data (Survey) or to act quickly with less information (Targeted Message)? What are the pros and cons of each?"*
 - **Messaging:** *"When you drafted your follow-up message after the survey, how did you use the data to make it more effective?"*

Phase 5: The Battlefield & Year-End Review

- **Student Action:** Students review their performance against competitors before advancing to the next year.
- **Facilitator's Role:** Facilitate a comparative analysis and prepare students for the next year.
 - **Discussion Prompts:**
 - *"Who gained the most market share this year and why? Did their marketing spend play a big role?"*
 - *"Notice that competitors' USPs have evolved for the next year. How will you need to adapt your strategy to stay competitive?"*

4. Core Simulation Mechanics (For the Instructor)

Understanding the underlying logic will help you guide students more effectively.

- **USP Evaluation:** The initial company valuation is not random. The `aiEvaluation` function scores USPs based on keywords related to modern business trends (e.g., AI, sustainability, D2C models) and penalizes generic terms (e.g., 'good', 'reliable'). Higher scores lead to higher initial turnover and a better growth rate (CAGR).
- **Marketing Funnel:** The process is a direct simulation of a marketing funnel:
 1. **Budget** determines the **Total Leads**.
 2. The **Initial Message's** effectiveness (`calculateSimilarity` function) determines the first wave of **Conversions**.
 3. Follow-up campaigns on **Remaining Leads** offer further chances to convert, with data-driven approaches (surveys) being more effective but costly.
- **Market Evolution:** Each year, competitors' base turnovers grow by their individual CAGR, and the total customer pool grows by the sector's CAGR. This creates a dynamic environment where standing still means falling behind. The `yearlyUSPs` data structure in the code dictates how competitor advantages evolve.

5. Post-Simulation Debrief

After the 5-year simulation concludes, lead a final discussion to consolidate learning.

- **Key Reflection Questions:**
 - *"What was the most impactful decision you made during the simulation?"*
 - *"If you could start over, what would be your initial strategy now?"*
 - *"Which was more important: a brilliant initial strategy or the ability to adapt year after year?"*
 - *"How does the concept of evolving USPs in the game reflect real-world industries like smartphones or electric vehicles?"*
 - *"What did the simulation teach you about the relationship between marketing spend, messaging, and actual customer acquisition?"*

By guiding students through these phases and discussions, you can turn the Sector Shaker Challenge into a powerful and memorable learning experience.

